

CRAM SHEET

Channel Theory – Concept, Nomenclature, Flow of Qi

12 Meridians · 3 Circuits · Quiz 1 Ready

12 MERIDIANS

6 Yin + 6 Yang
3 Hand + 3 Foot each

3 CIRCUITS

Outer / Inner / Middle
4 meridians each

15 COLLATERALS

12 primary + Du + Ren
+ Spleen's Great Luo

How to use this

This is the foundation everything else builds on - know it cold before Week 2.
The circulation rule (chest-hand-head-foot-chest) is the single most tested fact in the course.
Draw each circuit by hand, more than once - Dr. Zhang's own studying advice.

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What Is a Channel?

'Channels' (Jing-Luo) is the umbrella term covering BOTH Meridians (Jing, the primary pathways - like a river) AND Collaterals (Luo, the branches - smaller networks connecting meridians to tissues and organs).

The full system:

- 12 Primary Meridians (Jing) - the main rivers
- 15 Collaterals (Luo) - 12 from each primary meridian's own Luo-connecting point, plus the Luo of Du Mai, Ren Mai, and the Spleen's Great Luo (Dabao)
- 12 Divergent Meridians - branch from the primary meridians, distribute on chest/abdomen/head, deepen the Zang-Fu relationship (detail taught later in the course)
- 12 Muscle (Sinew) Regions - distribution of the primary meridians into the muscular system
- 12 Cutaneous Regions - the most superficial layer, where channel Qi reflects on the skin
- 8 Extraordinary Vessels - Du, Ren, Chong, Dai, Yinwei, Yangwei, Yinqiao, Yangqiao; act as reservoirs of Qi and Blood, closely connected to the Kidney, regulating the primary meridians as needed (detail taught later)

Zang-Fu Organs

Zang (Yin) - 6 organs

- Lung (LU)
- Spleen (SP)
- Heart (HT)
- Liver (LR)
- Kidney (KI)
- Pericardium (PC)

Fu (Yang) - 6 organs

- Large Intestine (LI)
- Stomach (ST)
- Small Intestine (SI)
- Bladder (BL)
- Gallbladder (GB)
- San Jiao (SJ)

3-Part Nomenclature

1. Hand or Foot (location of the pathway)
2. Yin or Yang (nature / medial-lateral surface)
3. Zang or Fu (pertaining organ)

e.g. 'Lung Meridian of Hand-Taiyin', 'Stomach Meridian of Foot-Yangming'

History – Which Came First: Channels or Points?

Answer: CHANNELS (*Mawangdui Silk Manuscripts predate point-specific texts*).

Origins (c. 2000+ years ago): Theoretical foundation laid in China; earliest surviving textual evidence is the Mawangdui Silk Manuscripts (Western Han Dynasty tomb), which describe the Yin and Yang meridians but predate point-specific texts.

Formalization (Zhou & Han Dynasties): The Huangdi Neijing (Yellow Emperor's Inner Canon) - read as two volumes, Su Wen (Basic Questions) and Ling Shu (Miraculous Pivot) - details the location, properties, and uses of acupuncture points, laying the foundation of modern practice.

Spread to East Asia (6th century CE): Channel theory and acupuncture practice spread to East Asian countries neighboring China.

Spread to the West (17th century onward): Acupuncture reached Europe and, later, North America.

Modern Recognition (Present day): Recognized by the WHO as an evidence-based complementary therapy and integrated into healthcare systems worldwide; modern research reinterprets meridians as networks integrating neural, circulatory, connective-tissue, and bioelectrical processes rather than fixed anatomical structures like nerves or blood vessels.

Meridians vs. Collaterals

Aspect	Meridians (Jingmai)	Collaterals (Luomai)
Meaning	Pathway	Network
Standing	Trunk	Branch
Distribution	Vertical line	Running amok (irregular)
Depth	Deep	Shallow
Number	Few (12 Primary)	Many (15 named + further branching)
Function	Leading	Supplement and bond

The 12 Primary Meridians

Ab	Name	Classification	Direction	Circuit
LU	Lung	Hand Taiyin	Chest -> Hand	Outer (Anterior)
LI	Large Intestine	Hand Yangming	Hand -> Head	Outer (Anterior)
ST	Stomach	Foot Yangming	Head -> Foot	Outer (Anterior)
SP	Spleen	Foot Taiyin	Foot -> Chest	Outer (Anterior)
HT	Heart	Hand Shaoyin	Chest -> Hand	Inner (Posterior)
SI	Small Intestine	Hand Taiyang	Hand -> Head	Inner (Posterior)
BL	Bladder	Foot Taiyang	Head -> Foot	Inner (Posterior)
KI	Kidney	Foot Shaoyin	Foot -> Chest	Inner (Posterior)
PC	Pericardium	Hand Jueyin	Chest -> Hand	Middle
SJ	San Jiao (Triple Burner)	Hand Shaoyang	Hand -> Head	Middle
GB	Gallbladder	Foot Shaoyang	Head -> Foot	Middle
LR	Liver	Foot Jueyin	Foot -> Chest	Middle

The 3 Circuits

Outer Circuit (Anterior)

Taiyin / Yangming

LU (chest->hand) -> LI (hand->head) -> ST (head->foot) -> SP (foot->chest)

Inner Circuit (Posterior)

Shaoyin / Taiyang

HT (chest->hand) -> SI (hand->head) -> BL (head->foot) -> KI (foot->chest)

Middle Circuit (Middle/Lateral)

Jueyin / Shaoyang

PC (chest->hand) -> SJ (hand->head) -> GB (head->foot) -> LR (foot->chest)

Direction of Qi Flow

Yin meridians of the HAND
 Yang meridians of the HAND
 Yang meridians of the FOOT
 Yin meridians of the FOOT

Chest -> Hand
 Hand -> Head
 Head -> Foot
 Foot -> Chest/Abdomen

Where Meridians Meet

Hand Yin meets Hand Yang at the FINGERS

e.g. LU7's branch meets LI1 at the index finger

Hand Yang meets Foot Yang at the FACE

e.g. LI ends at LI20, ST begins there

Foot Yang meets Foot Yin at the TOES

e.g. ST ends at ST45, SP begins at SP1

Foot Yin meets Hand Yin at the CHEST

completes the full 12-channel loop back to the next circuit

Meridian Clock (24 hr)

■ LU : 3-5 AM
 ■ LI : 5-7 AM
 ■ ST : 7-9 AM
 ■ SP : 9-11 AM
 ■ HT : 11 AM-1 PM
 ■ SI : 1-3 PM
 ■ BL : 3-5 PM
 ■ KI : 5-7 PM
 ■ PC : 7-9 PM
 ■ SJ : 9-11 PM
 ■ GB : 11 PM-1 AM
 ■ LR : 1-3 AM

Metal / Earth / Fire / Water / Wood + Ministerial Fire (PC/SJ)

3 Functions of Meridians

Transporting

Transport Qi and Blood to nourish the organs, skin, muscles, tendons, and bones; keep Yin-Yang in harmony throughout the body.

Resisting (Defending)

Defend the body against disease - meridians help resist pathogens and reflect symptoms/signs when something is wrong.

Treatment

Transmit needling sensation and regulate deficiency and excess conditions - the basis for using meridians and points clinically.

Rapid Recall – Channel Theory

Read this one last, on the way in

The “ONLY” List

Term for the whole system (meridians + collaterals)

Channels

Number of Zang (Yin) organs

6

Number of Fu (Yang) organs

6

Total collaterals (12 primary + Du + Ren + Spleen's Great Luo)

15

Circuit containing HT, SI, BL, KI

Inner (Posterior)

Circuit containing PC, SJ, GB, LR

Middle

Exam Traps

- 'Meridians' means the 12 Primary Meridians specifically. 'Channels' is the whole system - meridians AND collaterals.
- The location-based names (Taiyin/Yangming = anterior, etc.) describe medial/lateral POSITION on the limb, not organ function - don't conflate the two.
- Direction of flow depends on BOTH hand/foot AND yin/yang together - all four combinations are different (chest->hand, hand->head, head->foot, foot->chest).
- The Middle Circuit's Yang channel is San Jiao (Triple Burner/Trampl Burner), not to be confused with Small Intestine.